



SOUTHERN LATITUDES

The star-rich path of the Milky Way makes a glorious sight in the southern sky. It extends from the western horizon and climbs high in the sky to the south, before descending to the east. En route it passes Sirius and incorporates Carina, Crux and Centaurus, and the tail of Scorpius, the scorpion. Crux is almost due south and well placed for observation. The sky overhead, above Crux, is barren by comparison. It contains the long meandering body of Hydra, the water snake.

Crux and Carina

The Milky Way flows from top to bottom in this view of the southern-hemisphere sky. The four stars that form the southern cross, Crux, can be seen at the top left of the image. Below are the stars of Carina, which represent the keel of a ship.

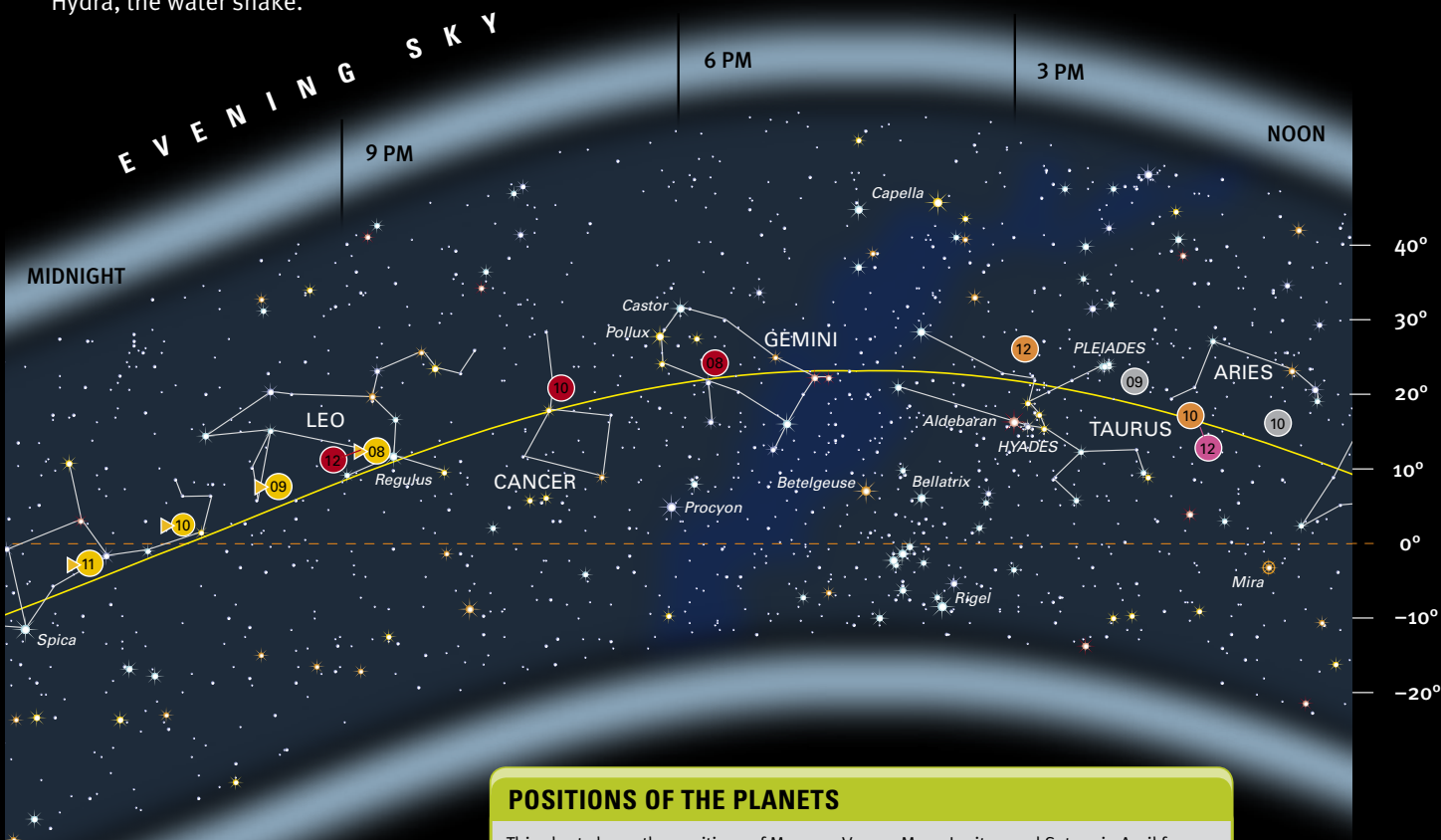
Acux, the brightest star in the constellation Crux, marks the base of the cross. To the naked eye it is a single star of magnitude 0.8, but through a small telescope it is seen as a pair of stars. Beta (β) Crucis marks the left of the cross; it is a blue-white giant of magnitude 1.3. Between this star and the prominent dark nebula known as the Coalsack is the sparkling Jewel Box cluster. Also known as NGC 4755, this is an open star cluster visible to the naked eye. Binoculars or a small telescope will show its individual stars.

Looking north, Leo is still well placed but is heading for the western horizon. To the right of its bright star Regulus are five galaxies visible with binoculars. The bright stars Spica in Virgo and Arcturus in Boötes shine bright in the northeastern sky. Procyon is still visible in the northwest, but Gemini is now moving below the horizon.



The Sombrero Galaxy

Also known as M104 or NGC 4594, the Sombrero Galaxy is a spiral galaxy in Virgo. Its dark dust lane and bulbous core resemble the traditional Mexican hat after which it is named. It is seen almost edge-on and appears elongated in a small telescope. The dark lane is visible through a larger instrument.



POSITIONS OF THE PLANETS

This chart shows the positions of Mercury, Venus, Mars, Jupiter, and Saturn in April from 2008 to 2012. The planets are represented by colored dots, while the number inside the dot indicates the year. For all planets apart from Mercury, the dot indicates the planet's position on April 15. Mercury is shown only when it is at greatest elongation (see p.14)—for the specific date of elongation, refer to the table on the facing page.

Mercury Venus Mars Jupiter Saturn

EXAMPLES

09 Mars's position on April 15, 2009

09 Saturn's position on April 15, 2009. The arrow indicates that the planet is in retrograde motion (see p.14)